EMPATHY & MIND

A PRACTICAL GUIDE FOR PARENTS & TEACHERS

The Child Emotional Regulation & *Inclusive Learning* Toolkit

Visual co-regulation cards, sensory decompression station layouts and math-anxiety de-escalation scripts you can use today, at home and in the classroom.



12 cut-out cards · 2 station floor plans · 30+ ready scripts · Ages 4–12

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START HERE

Calm is *contagious.* So is panic.

Children don't learn to calm down by being told to. They learn by borrowing calm from the adults around them, again and again, until it becomes their own. This toolkit turns that idea into things you can print, set up and say.

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How to use the symbols

Card: print, cut out, laminate if you can.

Script: words to say out loud, in your own voice.

Layout: set up a physical space.

Chart: track patterns over a week.



Hi, I'm Bhumika

Psychology undergraduate (Sociology minor), former Mathematics Subject Matter Expert, and someone who has spent a lot of time teaching children.

"Every child, whatever their background or abilities, deserves to grow somewhere that respects their dignity."

Please read: what this guide is and isn't

This is an **educational resource** drawn from published developmental psychology. It is **not** a diagnosis, therapy or a substitute for a qualified professional. If a child's distress is frequent, intense, getting worse, or includes any risk of harm, please contact a licensed clinical psychologist, paediatrician or occupational therapist (see page 18). Every child is different, so adapt what works and drop what doesn't.

The 4-Pillar Empathy & Growth Model behind this toolkit

a continuous loop

1 · Developmental Understanding
Look past "bad behaviour" to the need underneath

→

2 · Neuro-Inclusive Learning
Break maths into small, low-load steps

→

3 · Co-Regulation Literacy
Adults calm first, then teach feelings words

→

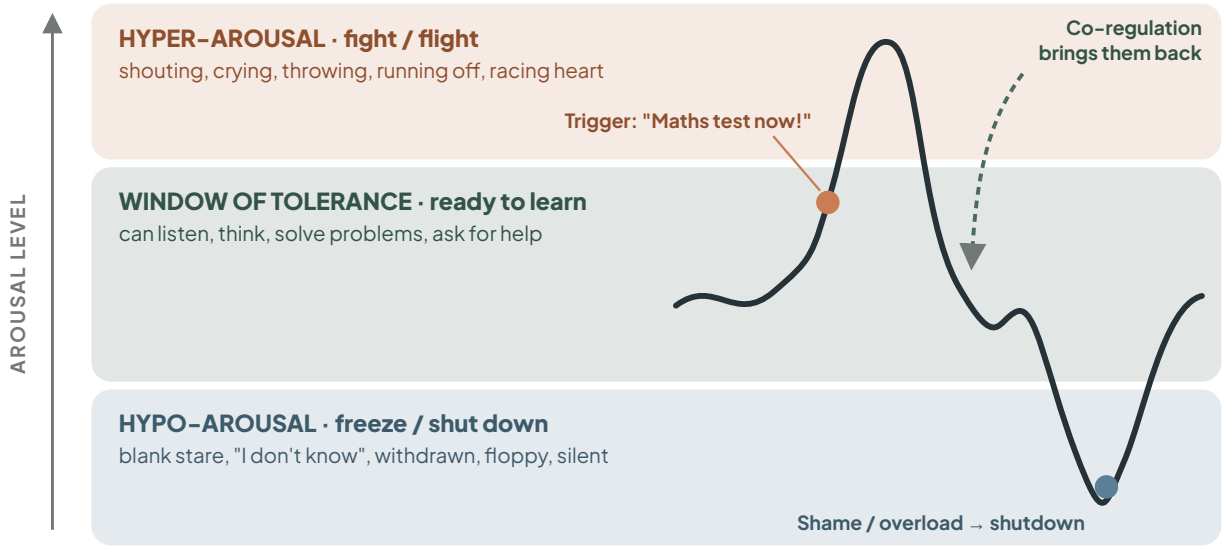
4 · Home–School Synergy
Same words, cards and routines in both places

Pages 3–5 · 6–12 · 13–17 · 18

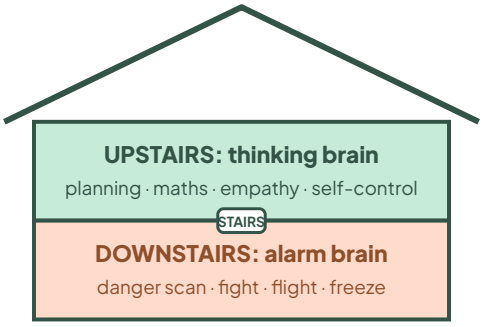
SECTION 1 · UNDERSTANDING

Why children *"flip their lid"*

A child can only think, learn and listen while their nervous system is inside the **window of tolerance** (Siegel, 1999). Push them out of it, through fear, overload or shame, and the thinking brain goes offline. What looks like defiance is often a body in survival mode.



The two-storey brain



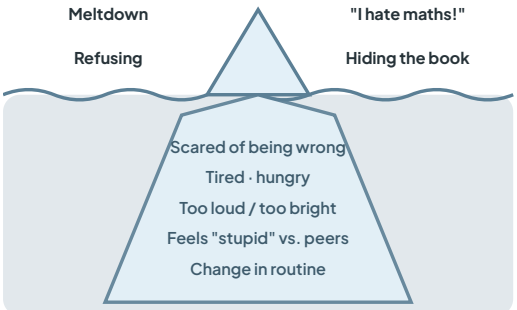
Under stress, the "staircase" closes and the alarm takes over (Siegel & Bryson, 2011). The thinking brain is still developing well into the mid-20s, so children need adults to act as their "upstairs" for a while.

The order that works: *3 Rs*



Dr Bruce Perry's sequence explains why lectures fail mid-meltdown: we jump to step 3 while the child is stuck at step 1. **Connect before you correct.**

> **Quick test:** can the child answer a simple question like "Water or juice?" If not, they're outside the window. Skip the teaching for now.



Behaviour is communication: the iceberg

What we **see** above the water is usually the smallest part. The real driver is underneath: an unmet need, a fear, or a body that is overloaded. Before reacting, ask yourself:

- **What is this behaviour trying to tell me?**
- **What happened just before?** (the trigger)
- **Is this a "won't" or a "can't right now"?** Most of the time it's a can't.
- **What need would make this behaviour unnecessary?**

Developmental-understanding pillar: root cause before response.

SECTION 1 · CO-REGULATION

Lending your calm, *until it's theirs*

Co-regulation is the warm, responsive back-and-forth through which an adult helps a child manage big feelings, through tone of voice, facial expression, posture, rhythm and presence. Over thousands of repetitions it builds the child's own **self-regulation** (Murray et al., 2015).



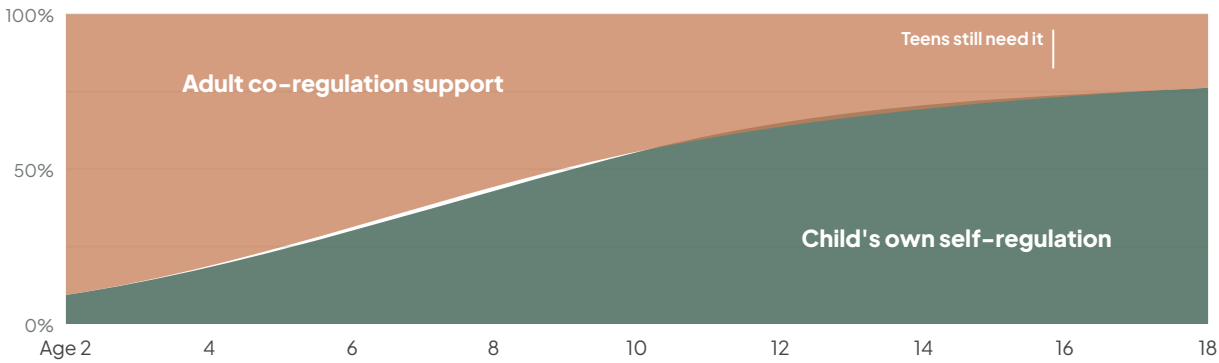
What "lending calm" looks like

- **Voice** — Lower, slower, softer. Fewer words than feels natural.
- **Face** — Soft eyes, relaxed jaw. Not a forced smile.
- **Body** — Get down to eye level, side-on, open hands, never towering.
- **Rhythm** — Breathe slowly and audibly. Children often sync to it.
- **Presence** — "I'm right here." Stay close, without crowding.

Myth: "If I comfort them, I'm rewarding the tantrum."
Reality: calming a child's body is not the same as giving in to a demand. You can hold a boundary *and* offer comfort: "The answer is still no, and I'll stay with you while you're upset."

From co-regulation to self-regulation, across childhood

Illustrative model, not measured data



Concept: the balance shifts with age, but adult support never falls to zero. Adolescents still benefit from co-regulation (Murray, Rosanbalm et al., 2015, OPRE Report #2015-82).

Everyday co-regulation micro-moments

Morning
Wake them slowly with a hand on the back and a quiet voice, not a shout from the doorway.

Drop-off
Same short goodbye ritual every day: hug, "see you at 3", wave. Predictable means safe.

Homework
Sit beside them, not across. Breathe together before the first sum (page 16).

Bedtime
Ask "best bit, hard bit" of the day. Listen and don't fix. Dim lights and a slower pace.

SECTION 1 · ADULT FIRST

Put on *your own* oxygen mask

A dysregulated adult cannot co-regulate a dysregulated child. Before any card or script, check your own body. It takes 60 seconds, and it is the single most powerful tool in this guide.

My stress gauge



If you're at TENSE or FLOODED, reset first.

Body signals to notice in yourself

- ☐ Clenched jaw
- ☐ Raised shoulders
- ☐ Fast, shallow breath
- ☐ Louder voice
- ☐ Hot face / neck
- ☐ "Lecture" mode
- ☐ Thinking "always/never"
- ☐ Wanting to win

10-second body resets

Drop your shoulders · Unclench your hands · Feel your feet · Sip water · Long out-breath

The 60-second S.T.O.P. reset

S — **Stop.** Pause for one beat before reacting. Silence is allowed.

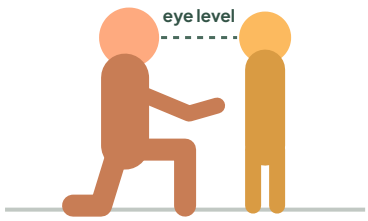
T — **Take a breath.** In through the nose, longer out through the mouth (try in for 4, out for 6).

O — **Observe.** "My shoulders are up. My child is scared, not giving me a hard time on purpose."

P — **Proceed** with one small, calm action: kneel, soften your voice, pick a card.

Self-talk swaps

~~"He's doing this to annoy me."~~	→ "He's struggling, not misbehaving."
~~"I have to fix this now."~~	→ "I just need to be the calm one."
~~"Everyone is judging me."~~	→ "My child matters more than the audience."
~~"I've failed as a parent / teacher."~~	→ "Ruptures can be repaired."



Body language that says "you're safe"

✓ **Kneel or sit** at the child's eye level, slightly to the side.

× **Standing over** them with crossed arms.

✓ **Open palms**, arms relaxed, no pointing.

× **Demanding eye contact.** Many children (especially neurodivergent ones) regulate better without it.

When you lose your cool: the 4-step repair

Repair teaches more than perfection ever could.

1 Pause
Take your own break first. Repair needs a calm adult.

2 Own it
"I shouted. That wasn't okay, and it's not your fault."

3 Reconnect
"I love you even when we're both upset."

4 Plan together
"Next time, what could we both try?"

SECTION 2 · CUT-OUT CARDS

Co-regulation cards: *breathe & body*

Print, cut along the dashed lines, and keep them on a ring. **Do the card *with* the child**. Your body is the demonstration. Let the child choose when they can.

CARD 1 · AGES 4+
Balloon Breath

Put your hands on your tummy. Breathe in slowly through your nose and **fill your balloon**… now let the air out **slooooowly** through your mouth. Let's do 3 balloons.



Adult tip: make your out-breath audible and longer than your in-breath. A longer exhale helps the body slow down.

CARD 2 · AGES 3+
Smell the Flower, Blow the Candle

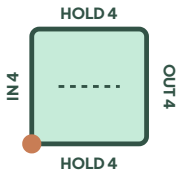
Hold up one finger as a flower. **Smell** it slowly… mmm. Now your finger is a candle. **Blow** it out gently, but don't let it go out too fast!



Adult tip: great for little ones who can't follow counting yet. Hold the "candle" finger in front of your own mouth too.

CARD 3 · AGES 7+
Square Breathing

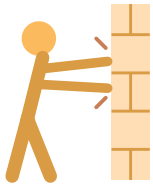
Trace the square with your finger. Go up: **breathe in** 2–3–4. Across: **hold** 2–3–4. Down: **breathe out** 2–3–4. Across: **hold** 2–3–4.



Adult tip: if holding feels hard or scary, skip the holds and just do "in 4, out 4". Never force breath-holding.

CARD 4 · AGES 4+
Wall Push

Put both hands flat on the wall. **Push as hard as you can**, like you're moving a mountain! Count to 10… now relax. Shake your hands out. Again?



Adult tip: heavy "push" work gives the muscles and joints deep pressure input (proprioception), which many children find calming.

CARD 5 · AGES 5+
Butterfly Hug

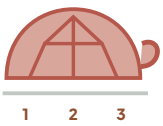
Cross your arms over your chest and rest your hands on your shoulders. Your arms are **butterfly wings**. Tap left, right, left, right… slowly, like a butterfly resting.



Adult tip: do 30–60 seconds while breathing slowly. Discreet enough to use at a desk or before a test.

CARD 6 · AGES 3+
Turtle Shell

When feelings get too big, a turtle goes into its shell. **Curl up small**, hug your knees, and take **3 slow breaths** inside your shell. Come out when you feel ready.



Adult tip: a self-chosen "shell" (a blanket, a tent) gives the child a sense of control. Stay close, quiet and available.

SECTION 2 · CUT-OUT CARDS

Co-regulation cards: *senses & words*

These cards move from calming the body toward **naming feelings and making choices**. Use them once the child is a little calmer (thermometer level 3 or below, page 8).

CARD 7 · AGES 6+

5-4-3-2-1 Senses

Let's be detectives! Find **5** things you can see, **4** you can touch, **3** you can hear, **2** you can smell, and **1** you can taste.

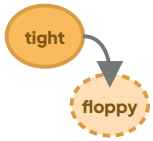


Adult tip: grounding pulls attention out of worry and into the present. Make it a whisper game for younger children.

CARD 8 · AGES 4+

Squeeze the Lemon

Pretend you're holding a lemon in each hand. **Squeeze, squeeze, squeeze** all the juice out! Hold… and **drop** the lemons. Feel how floppy and soft your hands are now.

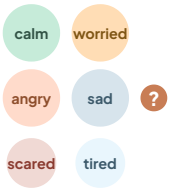


Adult tip: a child-friendly form of progressive muscle relaxation. Contrast teaches what "relaxed" feels like. Try shoulders and toes too.

CARD 9 · AGES 5+

Name It to Tame It

Big feelings get smaller when we give them a name. Point to your feeling and say: **"I feel _____ because _____."**



Adult tip: naming emotions engages the thinking brain (Siegel). Model it yourself: "I feel frustrated because the bus is late."

CARD 10 · AGES 3+

Hug, High-Five or Space?

What would help you right now? **Point to one.** All three are okay. You can change your mind.

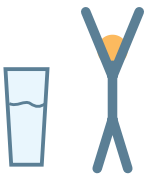


Adult tip: respecting "space" builds trust and body autonomy. Stay nearby: "I'll be right here when you're ready."

CARD 11 · AGES 4+

Sip & Stretch

Take **5 slow sips** of water. Now **reach up** high like a tree… sway in the wind… and **flop down** like a rag doll.



Adult tip: swallowing and stretching are quick "reset" actions. Keep a named water bottle at the calm station.

CARD 12 · AGES 4+

Rocket Countdown

Let's count down slowly from **10 to 1** together. Each number, breathe out a little more. At **"blast off"**, stretch your arms up high!

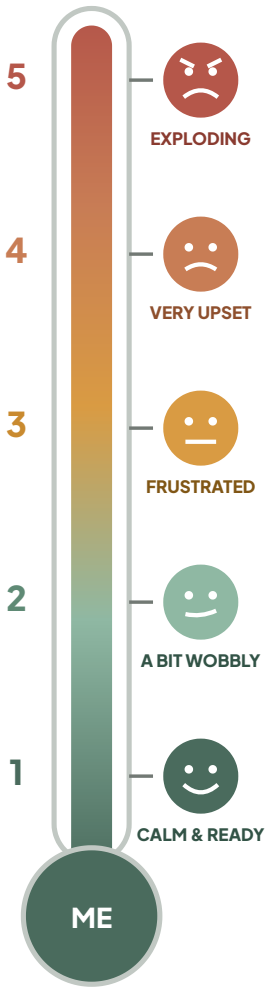


Adult tip: counting *down* signals an ending is coming. Useful for transitions ("When we reach 1, we'll pack up").

SECTION 2 · CHECK-IN TOOL

The feelings *thermometer*

A shared, visual 1–5 scale gives children a way to say how big a feeling is without needing many words, and tells adults **which response fits**. Stick one on the fridge and one in the classroom, and use the same words in both.



LEVEL	WHAT YOU MIGHT SEE	WHAT THE ADULT DOES	WHAT TO SAY
5	Hitting, screaming, throwing, running, or total shutdown	**Safety only.** Remove hazards and audience. Few or no words. Stay near.	*"You're safe. I'm here."*
4	Crying hard, shouting, tearing paper, "I can't!"	Lower your voice, kneel, breathe audibly. Offer one card, not a list.	*"Breathe with me. Balloon breath."*
3	Groaning, fidgeting, rubbing out hard, "This is stupid"	Name the feeling, offer a break or a smaller step.	*"This feels frustrating. Break or one tiny step?"*
2	Sighing, slowing down, asking "how long?"	Check in, validate, chunk the task.	*"Looks a bit wobbly. Just three more, then a stretch."*
1	Engaged, asking questions, can laugh	Teach, practise, praise effort. Build skills now.	*"You stuck with that. How did you work it out?"*

Teach it when calm

Practise pointing to levels during happy, ordinary moments, so the tool is familiar before it's needed.

Adults use it too

"I'm at a 3 right now, so I'm going to do a balloon breath." Modelling makes it normal, not a punishment.

Levels 4–5: no lessons

Teaching, reasoning or consequences wait until level 1–2. The thinking brain needs to be back online.

My week on the thermometer (child circles a number, adult helps)

	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri
After school	1 2 3 4 5	1 2 3 4 5	1 2 3 4 5	1 2 3 4 5	1 2 3 4 5
Homework	1 2 3 4 5	1 2 3 4 5	1 2 3 4 5	1 2 3 4 5	1 2 3 4 5

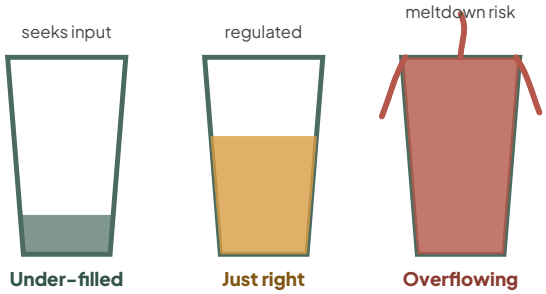
SECTION 3 · SENSORY DECOMPRESSION

Not five senses, *eight*

Besides sight, sound, touch, taste and smell, children process **movement and balance** (vestibular), **body position and muscle pressure** (proprioception) and **internal signals** like hunger, a full bladder or a racing heart (interoception). When any of these is overloaded or under-fed, regulation gets harder.



The sensory cup



Each child's "cup" has a different size. Noise, bright light, itchy uniforms, crowds and hunger all pour in. A **decompression station** helps empty an overflowing cup or fill an empty one.

Inclusion note: sensory differences are common in autistic children and those with ADHD, but *any* child can be overloaded on a hot, loud exam day. A calm station helps everyone. No diagnosis needed.

Seeker or avoider? Matching support to the child

SENSE	SENSORY SEEKER MAY…	TRY OFFERING	SENSORY AVOIDER MAY…	TRY OFFERING
Sound	hum, make noise, like loud music	Music with headphones, humming songs	cover ears, hate the pressure cooker or the school bell	Ear defenders, quiet corner, warnings before loud sounds
Touch	touch everything, fiddle constantly	Fidget tools, playdough, textured strip under desk	dislike labels, tags, messy hands, hugs	Soft clothes, offer choice before touching
Vestibular	spin, rock, never sit still	Movement breaks, wobble cushion, errands	fear swings, feel sick in cars	Slow, predictable movement, feet on floor
Proprioception	crash, push, chew collars and pencils	Wall pushes, carrying books, chewy snacks	seem "floppy", tire easily	Gentle heavy work, supportive seating
Sight	stare at lights or moving things	Calm glitter bottle, visual timers	squint, get distracted by busy walls	Plain workspace, softer lighting, fewer posters

Sensory processing varies widely. For persistent difficulties, an occupational therapist (OT) can complete a proper sensory assessment.

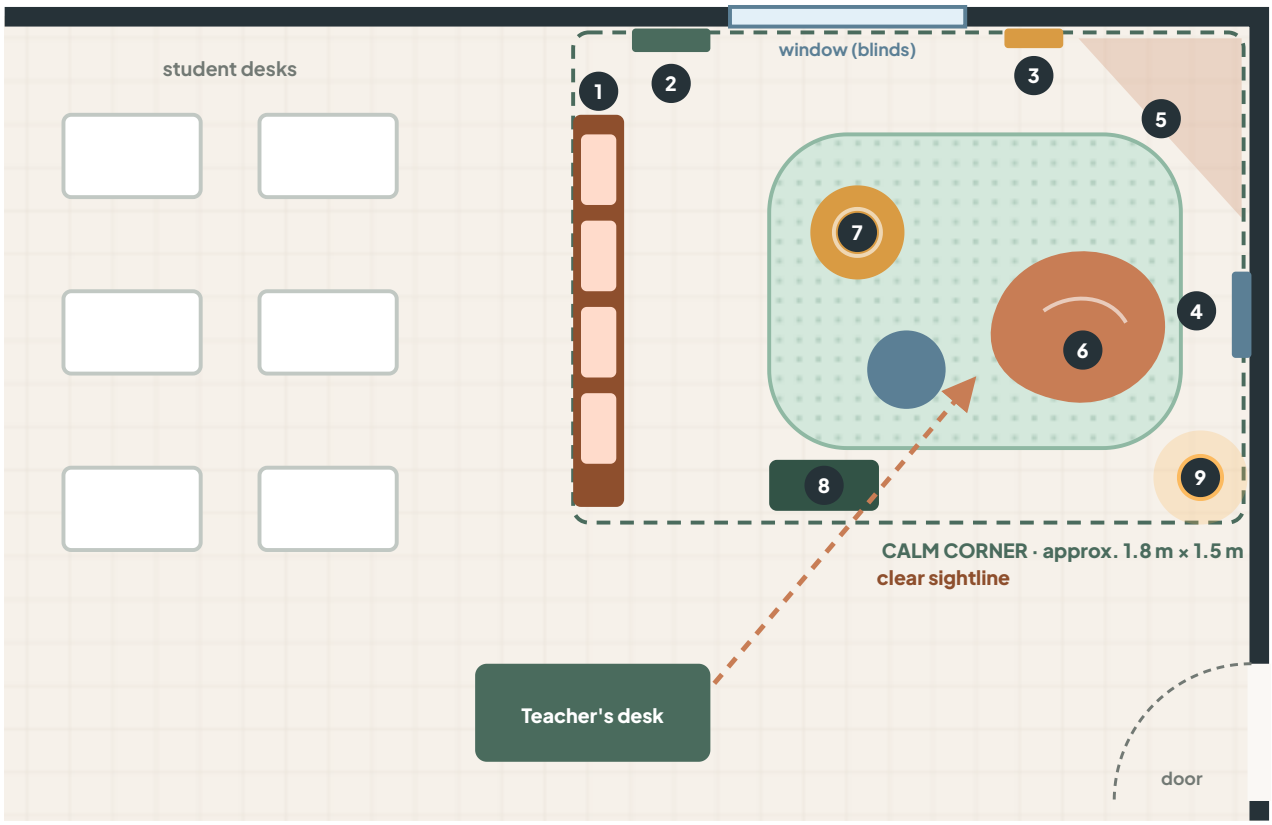
5-minute sensory audit of your room or classroom

- ☐ Is there a constant hum (fan, AC, traffic)?
- ☐ Are tube lights flickering or harsh?
- ☐ Are the walls crowded with posters?
- ☐ Is there one quiet, low-traffic corner?
- ☐ Can children move between tasks?
- ☐ Is water and a snack within reach?

SECTION 3 · STATION LAYOUT A

The classroom *calm corner*

A small, semi-enclosed space where any child can go to **reset, not to be punished**. It should feel cosy and slightly separate, while staying in the teacher's line of sight.



1. **Low divider shelf**: creates a sense of enclosure. Holds labelled bins.
2. **Feelings thermometer** poster at child eye height (page 8).
3. **Visual timer** or sand timers (3 & 5 min).
4. **Co-regulation card ring** on a hook (pages 6–7).
5. **Canopy / draped cloth**: dims light, adds privacy.
6. **Bean bag**: deep, hugging seat. Proprioceptive comfort.
7. **Floor cushions on a soft rug** to define the zone.
8. **Calm box**: fidgets, ear defenders, glitter bottle.
9. **Warm, soft lamp** instead of overhead tube light.

Placement rules

- Away from the door, the board and walkways
- Always visible from the teacher's usual position
- Never in a cupboard, corridor or behind a closed door

Keep it working

- Introduce it to the whole class on a calm day, and role-play using it
- One child at a time (two if peers co-regulate well)
- Refresh the calm box every few weeks so it stays interesting

Inside the calm box: one tool for each sense

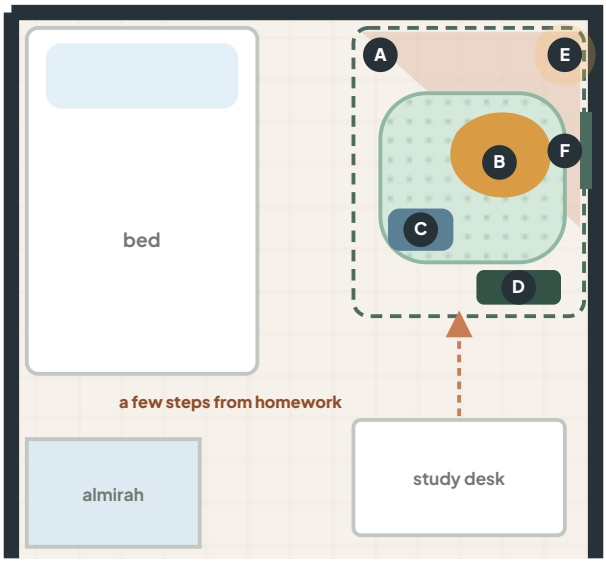
Ear defenders	Fidgets & dough	Glitter bottle	Stress ball	Mild scent pouch	Card ring
sound	touch	sight	proprioception	smell (optional)	pages 6–7

Check for allergies before adding scents or food items. Avoid small parts for under-5s.

SECTION 3 · STATION LAYOUT B

The home *decompression nook*

You don't need a spare room. A bedroom corner, the space beside a *diwan*, or under a staircase works well. What matters is that it's **predictable, soft, dim and always available**.



- **A** **Canopy:** a bedsheet or dupatta over two chair backs, or a small play tent
- **B** **Bean bag or folded razai** with pillows
- **C** **Ear defenders** or a soft cushion to hug
- **D** **Calm basket:** playdough, fidgets, a picture book, a glitter bottle
- **E** **Warm lamp** (switch off the tube light)
- **F** **Feelings thermometer + card ring** on the wall

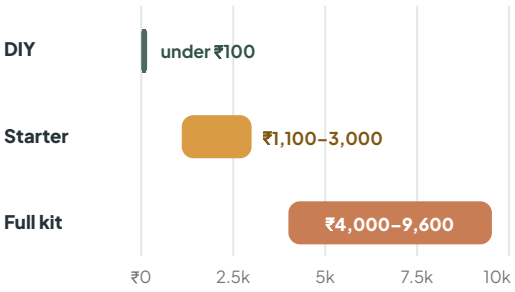
Siblings & small homes: agree on a "nook rule": whoever is in the nook gets quiet and space. Even a single floor cushion with a "calm" sign can work.

Safety: no cords, lit diyas or candles near fabric; keep canopies above head height and well secured. Use weighted items only after advice from an OT, and never over the face or neck.

Starter kit: indicative prices (India)

ITEM	STORE-BOUGHT	FREE / DIY SWAP
Bean bag / floor cushion	₹1,500–3,500	Folded razai + pillows
Kids' ear defenders	₹700–1,800	Nook away from TV / kitchen
Sand timers (1, 3, 5 min)	₹200–500	A 3-minute calm song
Fidget set	₹200–600	Homemade atta-salt playdough
Warm LED lamp / fairy lights	₹200–600	Existing table lamp
Play tent / canopy	₹1,200–2,500	Bedsheet over two chairs
Printing this toolkit (colour)	₹20–60	Draw your own faces

Three budgets, same benefits



Starter = timers + fidgets + ear defenders + printing. Full = all seven items. Ranges are indicative Indian online-retail prices (2026); actual prices vary by brand and city.

DIY: make a calm-down glitter bottle together (about ₹50)

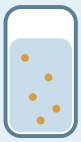
Shake it, then breathe slowly until the glitter settles (2–3 min)



1 · Bottle
Clean plastic bottle, ¾ warm water



2 · Glue
2–3 spoons clear glue, stir well



3 · Glitter
A spoon of glitter, food colour optional

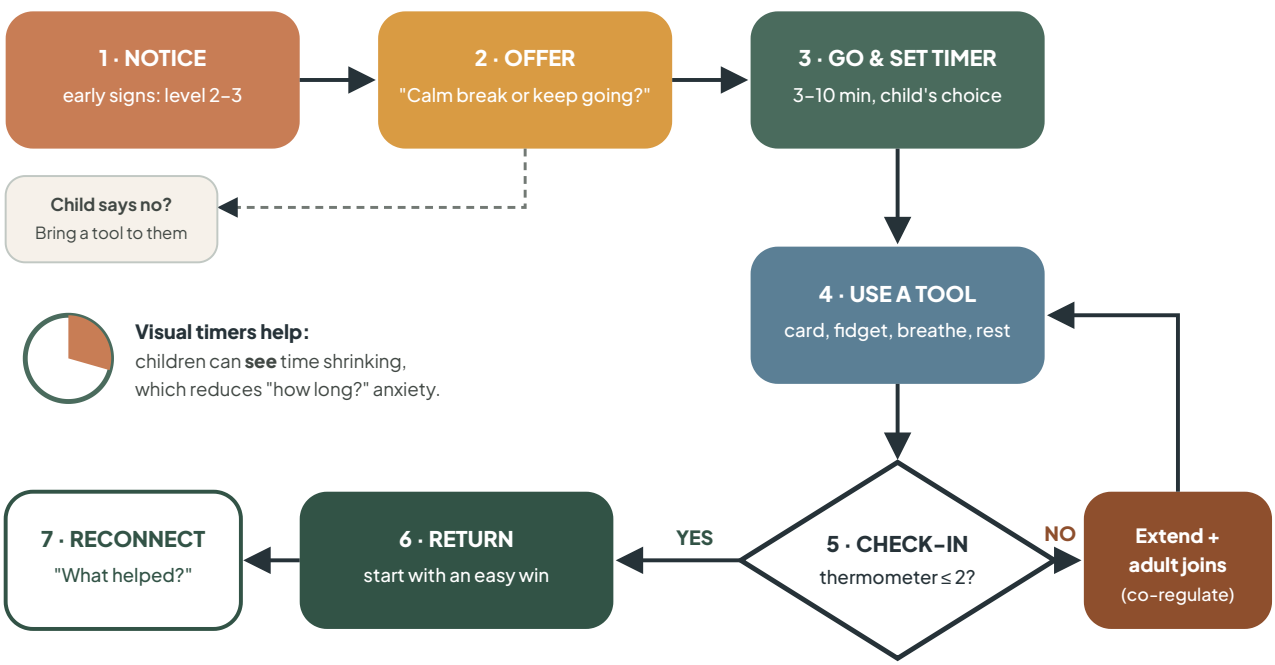


4 · Seal
Glue and tape the lid shut (adult step)

SECTION 3 · USING THE STATION

How a calm break *actually works*

The station only helps if it's used the same way every time. Follow this flow at home and in class, and children will learn the routine within a few weeks.



Calm break ≠ time-out

	TIME-OUT (PUNITIVE)	CALM BREAK (SUPPORTIVE)
Purpose	Consequence for behaviour	Help the body return to calm
Who chooses	Adult sends the child	Child chooses, or is offered
Feels like	Isolation, shame	Safety, comfort, control
Adult role	Withdraws attention	Stays available, co-regulates
Teaches	"Big feelings get me sent away"	"I can notice and manage feelings"

Our Calm Corner Promise

(print for the wall · read together)

- **I can come here** when my feelings are big.
- **I set the timer** and choose a tool.
- **I take care** of the things here.
- **I come back** when I'm at a 1 or 2.
- **A grown-up** will always help if I ask.

Making the return easy

No lecture

Welcome them back warmly. The reflection chat comes later, if at all.

"Welcome back. We're on question 4."

Easy first task

Give a task they're sure to get right, to rebuild confidence before the hard part.

"Start with this one. You know these."

Notice the skill

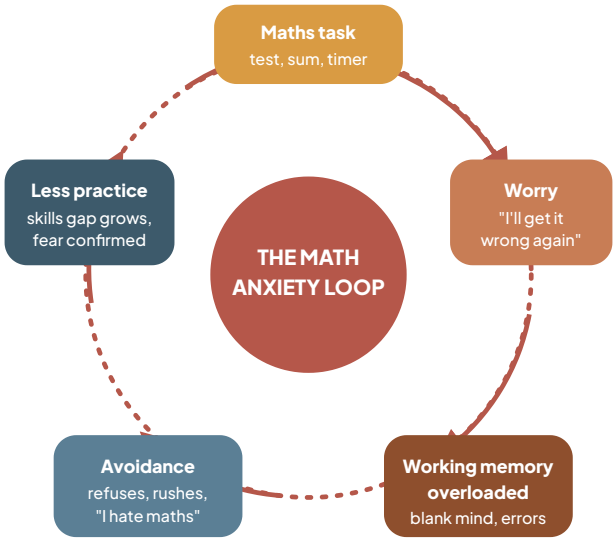
Praise the regulation itself, not "being good".

"You noticed you needed a break and took one. That's a big skill."

SECTION 4 · MATH ANXIETY

"I'm just bad at maths" *is usually a fear,* not a fact

Math anxiety is a feeling of tension and fear that interferes with working with numbers. It is **not** the same as low ability: worry uses up **working memory**, the brain's mental "scratchpad", so even capable children freeze and make mistakes (Ashcraft & Kirk, 2001).



Where to break the loop

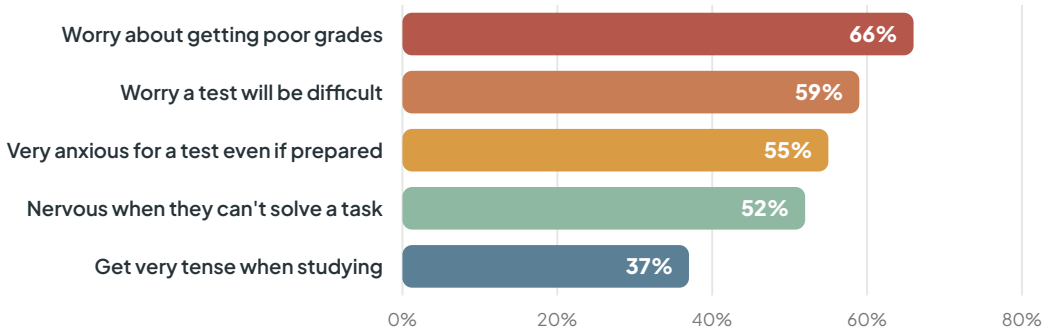
1. **The task:** shrink it, remove time pressure, start with a sure win.
2. **The worry:** name it, breathe, expressive writing (page 17).
3. **Working memory:** concrete objects, drawings, written steps so the brain holds less.
4. **Avoidance:** co-regulate, then "just the first step together".
5. **Practice:** short, frequent, low-stakes and playful.

The parent effect

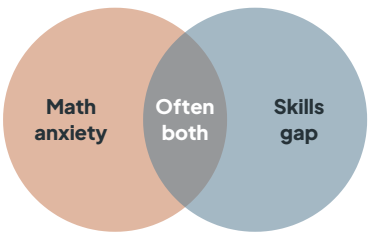
In a study of US first and second graders, children of math-anxious parents learned less maths across the school year and grew more anxious, **but only when those parents helped often with homework** (Maloney et al., 2015). Help isn't bad. *How* we help matters. See page 16.

How common is schoolwork anxiety? 15-year-olds, OECD average

Source: OECD PISA 2015



OECD (2017), *PISA 2015 Results (Vol. III): Students' Well-Being*, and *PISA in Focus* No. 71. General schoolwork anxiety, OECD average. Low achievers were more likely to feel very anxious even when well prepared (63% vs 46% of top achievers, in science).



Anxiety, a skills gap, or both?

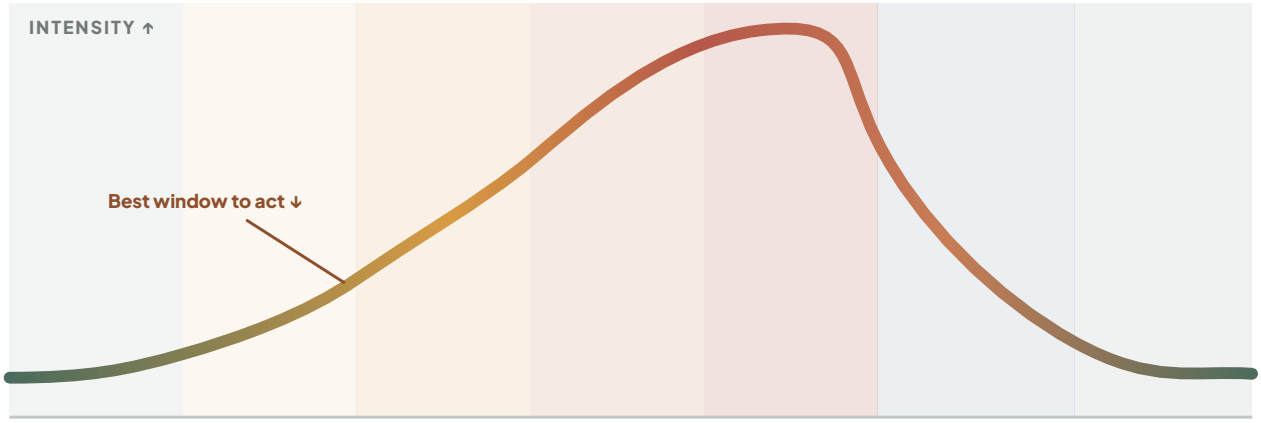
They feed each other, so support both at once: **calm the fear** (this section) **and** fill the gap with patient, step-by-step teaching.

When to look further: if a child still struggles with basic number sense (e.g. which of two numbers is bigger, counting on, telling the time) despite good teaching, ask the school about screening for a specific learning difficulty such as **dyscalculia**, by a qualified professional.

SECTION 4 · TIMING MATTERS

Catch it on the *way up*

Emotional outbursts usually follow a predictable curve (Colvin & Sugai's acting-out cycle). The **earlier** you step in, the easier it is. At the peak your only job is safety. Here is how the curve looks around a maths task.



1 Calm	2 Trigger	3 Agitation	4 Acceleration	5 Peak	6 De-escalation	7 Recovery
working, chatting	"Test on Friday" / hard word problem	sighs, taps, erases hard, "how long?"	"I can't!", argues, rips the page	screams, cries, throws, runs, or freezes	quieter, tired, confused, may withdraw	eager to reconnect, fragile
PREVENT routines, praise, teach skills	**REDIRECT EARLY** name it, shrink the task, offer a card or break	**CALM & FEW WORDS** no demands	**SAFETY** clear space, stay near, wait		**SOOTHE** water, rest, simple choices	**REPAIR** reconnect, reflect later

Early warning signs checklist · tick the ones you see in *this* child

Body

- [ ] Stomach-ache or "need the toilet" before maths
- [ ] Fidgeting, leg bouncing
- [ ] Tight shoulders, clenched fists
- [ ] Flushed face, teary eyes
- [ ] Chewing pencil or sleeves

Words

- [ ] "I'm stupid / dumb at this"
- [ ] "I hate maths"
- [ ] "How long is this going to take?"
- [ ] "Everyone else gets it"
- [ ] Sudden silence, "I don't know"

Behaviour

- [ ] Delaying: sharpening, water, toilet
- [ ] Rushing and guessing to "get it over with"
- [ ] Rubbing out until the page tears
- [ ] Copying, hiding worksheets
- [ ] Clowning to distract

Pattern spotting: if you tick 3+ signs regularly, note *when* they happen (time of day, type of task, after school?) on the tracker on page 18. Patterns tell you where to step in.

The curve in real life: Aarav, age 9, fractions homework

6:10 pm · Agitation
Sighs, erases hard. Mum **notices**, covers the page except Q1: "Just this one together."

6:14 · Acceleration
"I CAN'T!" Pencil thrown. Mum kneels, quiet voice: "Pencil down. Breathe with me."

6:20 · De-escalation
5 min in the nook with the glitter bottle. "Water or a stretch?" He picks water.

6:28 · Recovery
Back with roti pieces to show ½ and ¼. Finishes 3 questions. "You came back. That's brave."

SECTION 4 · SCRIPTS

What to say at *each stage*

Use your own voice and language (Hindi, English or a mix is perfect). What matters is the **tone, the pace and how few words you use**.

STAGES 2–3 · TRIGGER & AGITATION

Goal: redirect early

"I can see this one feels tricky. Let's look at just the first step together."

"Your brain is working hard. Want a balloon breath before we start?"

Do: sit beside, cover extra questions, offer a card or a break.
Avoid: ~~"It's easy!"~~ ~~"Just concentrate."~~ ~~"You did this yesterday."~~

STAGE 4 · ACCELERATION

Goal: calm, few words

"You're safe. I'm right here."

"Let's put the pencil down for now."

"Breathe with me... in... and out."

Do: lower your voice, slow down, remove the worksheet calmly.
Avoid: ~~"Calm down!"~~ ~~"If you don't finish, no TV."~~ Arguing or bargaining.

STAGE 5 · PEAK

Goal: safety only

"I'm going to stay here."

"I'll wait. Take your time."

Often **silence** is the best script. Your calm presence is the message.

Do: move hazards and onlookers away, keep your distance if they need it.
Avoid: touching without consent, questions, consequences, an audience.

STAGE 6 · DE-ESCALATION

Goal: soothe

"Your body is calming down. You did that."

"Water or a stretch?"

Do: simple either/or choices, rest, a snack.
Avoid: ~~"Now, why did you do that?"~~
Going straight back to the task.

STAGE 7 · RECOVERY

Goal: repair & reflect

"That was really hard. Thank you for coming back."

"What helped your body feel better? Let's remember that."

Do: reconnect warmly, plan for next time, restart with an easy win.
Avoid: shaming, retelling the incident to others in front of the child.

Hinglish calm phrases

"Main yahin hoon." I'm right here. **"Saath mein saans lete hain."** Let's breathe together.

"Koi baat nahi, galti se hi seekhte hain." It's okay, mistakes help us learn.

"Bas pehla step." Just the first step.

Fewer words as intensity rises

Calm — explain, teach

Agitation — short

Acceleration — few

Peak — near silence

De-escalation — simple

Recovery — talk, reflect

The L.E.S.S. rule

Lower your voice

Eye level, side-on

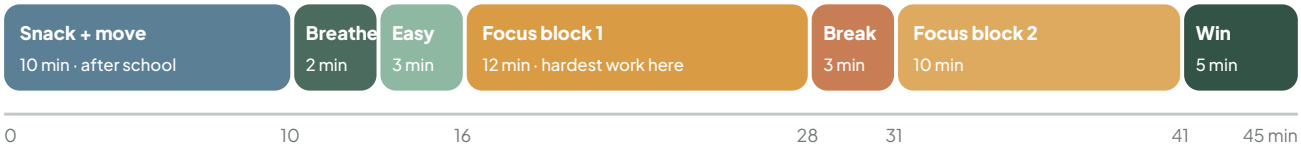
Slow your breathing

Short sentences

SECTION 4 · FOR PARENTS

Homework time, *without the tears*

A predictable routine lowers anxiety before the first sum is even attempted. Here's a sample 45-minute evening session for ages 7–11. Shorten the focus blocks for younger children.



End on a question they can answer, and praise the **effort and strategy**, not "being clever".

Scripts for the six most common homework moments

"I'm so stupid."

"You're not stupid. This is hard, and hard is different from impossible. Your brain is learning something new right now."

~~"Don't say that!"~~

"I hate maths!"

"Sounds like maths feels really frustrating today. What part feels the worst?"

~~"Maths is important, you have to like it."~~

Refuses to start

"Let's just read the first question together. Only reading, no writing yet."

~~"You're not getting up until it's done."~~

Crying over the worksheet

"It's okay to cry. Let's put this aside for a few minutes. I'm here. Balloon breath?"

~~"Stop crying, it's only homework."~~

Comparing with others

"Everyone's brain learns at its own speed. Let's look at how far you've come since last month."

~~"Your cousin scored 95. Why can't you?"~~

Gets one wrong

"Great mistake! Let's be detectives. Where did your thinking take a different path?"

~~"Careless again!"~~

If *you* feel anxious about maths too

- Avoid "I was never good at maths either". It can make the fear feel inherited and permanent.
- Ask questions instead of explaining: *"How did you think about it?" "Can you show me with objects?"*
- Use the school's method or a short video together, and learn alongside them.

Maths at home, stress-free

- Count rotis, split the bill at the sabzi market, measure for a recipe
- Board games: Ludo, Snakes & Ladders, Uno, dominoes
- Talk about numbers in everyday life, with no right or wrong answers

Praise that builds a resilient maths learner

~~"You're so smart!"~~ → **"You tried three different ways. That's how mathematicians work."**

~~"See, it was easy."~~ → **"That was tricky and you stuck with it."**

~~"Finally, you got it right."~~ → **"Drawing it really helped you, didn't it?"**

~~"Good boy / good girl."~~ → **"You asked for help when you needed it. Smart move."**

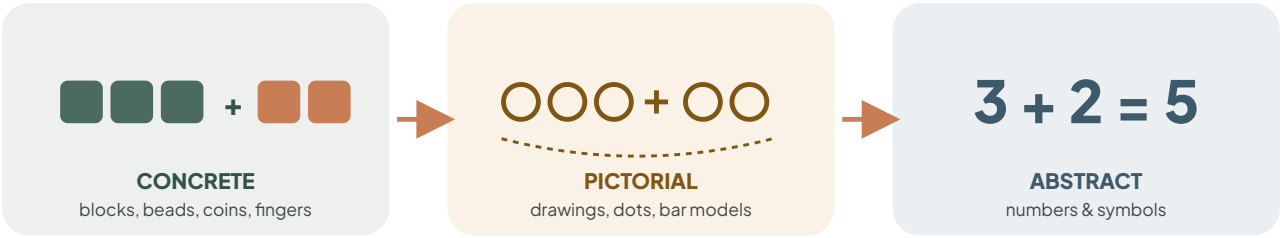
SECTION 4 · FOR TEACHERS

A classroom where *mistakes are safe*

Small changes in how maths is introduced, practised and assessed can lower anxiety for the whole class, and especially for children who are already struggling.

Reduce working-memory load: Concrete → Pictorial → Abstract

CPA approach



Anxious learners can step **back** a stage at any time. That's support, not failure.

Worry-dump writing

10 minutes writing about test worries just before a test improved scores in anxious students (Ramirez & Beilock, 2011).

Ease time pressure

Offer untimed practice. Keep speed drills private and self-paced, never a public race.

"My favourite mistake"

Share an anonymous error each week and celebrate the thinking that it reveals.

Private signals

A coloured card on the desk (green / amber / red) lets a child ask for help without speaking up.

Classroom scripts

MOMENT	TRY SAYING	INSTEAD OF
Before a test (whole class)	*"Notice how your body feels. Let's do three balloon breaths together. Feeling nervous just means this matters to you."*	~~"This test decides your final grade."~~
Child stuck, frozen (one-to-one)	*"Tell me what you do know about this question. Let's start there."*	~~"We just did this. Weren't you listening?"~~
"I'm dumb" said in front of the class	*"In this room, we're all still learning, me too. Let's figure it out together."* (follow up privately)	~~"Don't be silly." / ignoring it~~
Returning a test	*"Look for one thing you did well and one thing to practise. Marks show where we are today, not who you are."*	~~Reading marks aloud, ranking~~
After a meltdown	*"I'm glad you're feeling better. You're not in trouble. Let's find a way to make maths feel safer for you."*	~~Public consequences~~

Printable desk signal cards

✂ cut out, fold in half, stand on the desk

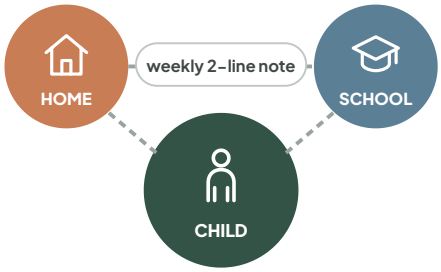
I'm okay
I'm working. Thanks!

I'm stuck
Could I have a hint, please?

I need a break
Can I use the calm corner?

SECTION 5 · HOME–SCHOOL SYNERGY

One child, *one shared language*



same thermometer · same cards
same calm words · same routine

Our shared calm plan (fill in together, keep a copy at home & school)

My early warning signs are…

My favourite calm cards are…

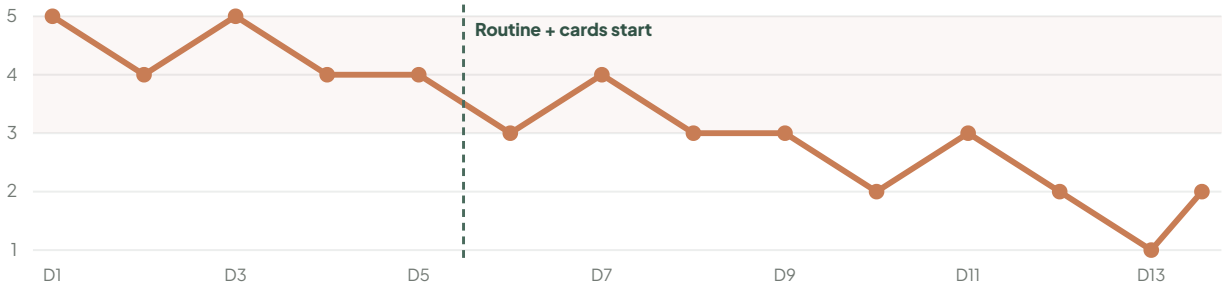
Words that help me…

Words / things that make it worse…

My calm place at school / home is…

Tracker: peak thermometer level during homework

Example data · for illustration



Log the highest level each day, plus a note on the trigger. Progress is rarely a straight line; look for the overall trend over 2–4 weeks.

⚠ When to seek professional help

- Meltdowns or shutdowns are frequent, intense, or worsening over weeks
- Ongoing stomach-aches, sleep problems or school refusal
- Talk of self-harm, hurting others, or not wanting to be alive. **Seek help immediately** (Tele-MANAS, India's government mental-health helpline: **14416** or 1–800–891–4416, free, 24×7)
- Persistent learning difficulties despite good support

Who to contact: paediatrician, licensed clinical / child psychologist (RCI-registered), occupational therapist, school counsellor.

Key references

Ashcraft, M. & Kirk, E. (2001). *J. Exp. Psychology: General*, 130(2). · Colvin, G. & Sugai, G. (1989). Managing escalating behavior. · Maloney, E. et al. (2015). *Psychological Science*, 26(9). · Murray, D. W. et al. (2015). Self-regulation and toxic stress, OPRE Report 2015–82. · OECD (2017). *PISA 2015 Results Vol. III.* · Perry, B. & Winfrey, O. (2021). *What Happened to You?* · Ramirez, G. & Beilock, S. (2011). *Science*, 331. · Siegel, D. (1999). *The Developing Mind.* · Siegel, D. & Bryson, T. (2011). *The Whole-Brain Child.*

Your 7–day starter plan

1. Read pp. 3–5
2. Print & cut the cards
3. Set up the calm space
4. Teach the thermometer
5. Try the homework routine
6. Share plan with teacher
7. Review the tracker



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